FIELD GUIDE · TEAM LEADERS, FIELD RESEARCHERS AND ENUMERATORS

# Field Data Collection Guide

How to collect accurate, ethical and secure data in the field: surveys, key informant interviews, focus group discussions and observation. A practical guide to keep in your bag.

Code of conduct · Consent and ethics · Confidentiality · Surveys · KIIs and FGDs · Observation · Data quality

Prepared by

**Aqil Shah Ayaz**

Data Analyst · Monitoring, Evaluation and Learning Expert

Free learning material

aqilshah-researcher.github.io

# Contents

This guide applies to any survey, evaluation, assessment or third-party monitoring assignment. Your project team will add the specific tools, sample and schedule.


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i **Who this guide is for**
**Team leaders** who supervise field teams, **field researchers** who run interviews and discussions, and **enumerators and surveyors** who collect survey data. Where a rule applies to one role only, the guide says so.

! **Project instructions come first**
If your project's protocol, donor requirements or local law say something stricter than this guide, follow the stricter rule and ask your team leader when in doubt.

PROFESSIONAL STANDARDS

# 01 Code of conduct

**BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO**

- Explain the standards expected of every field team member
- Recognize conflicts of interest and fraud
- Know what to do when something goes wrong

QUALITY

### Believe in good data

Every answer you record will inform decisions about real people. Record what you hear and see, never what you expect or prefer.

INTEGRITY

### Act professionally

Be polite, punctual, neutral and respectful of local customs. Dress modestly and keep a low profile.

HONESTY

### Zero tolerance for fraud

Never invent, copy or change answers, and never fill in a form for someone you did not interview. Fabricated data is grounds for dismissal.

INDEPENDENCE

### Avoid conflicts of interest

Tell your team leader at once if you know a respondent personally or have any link to the program being assessed.

GIFTS

### Accept nothing

Do not accept gifts, money, favors or meals from respondents, program staff or officials before, during or after data collection. Politely decline and report any offer.

ACCOUNTABILITY

### Own your work

Deliver what your contract and terms of reference require, on time. Report problems early rather than hiding them.

## Teamwork in the field

- Work closely with your team leader and other field researchers; share problems and solutions every day.
- Come to the field rested and ready to concentrate. Interviews need patience and full attention.
- Follow the agreed route, schedule and check-in times so the team always knows where you are.

! **If something goes wrong**
Report security incidents, harassment, complaints from respondents or any mistake in your data to your team leader the same day. Early reporting protects you, the respondents and the project.

ETHICS

# 02 Ethics and informed consent

**BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO**

- Obtain informed consent correctly
- Protect participants' privacy and wellbeing
- Respond safely to distress or a safeguarding concern

## Informed consent

1. Introduce yourself, your organization and the purpose of the study in simple words.
2. Read the consent statement aloud, word for word. Explain how long it will take, that taking part is voluntary and that the person can skip any question or stop at any time with no effect on any services they receive.
3. Explain how the information will be used and protected, and that names will not appear in any report.
4. Ask if they have questions, then ask clearly whether they agree to take part.
5. Record consent: verbal consent in the form for surveys; for KIIs and FGDs, a signed or recorded consent according to the project protocol. Ask separately for permission to audio record or take photos.
6. If the person says no, thank them, end politely and record the refusal. Never pressure anyone.

## Do no harm

- Interview in a calm, private and safe place where others cannot overhear.
- Pause if someone else joins or interrupts, and continue only when it is private again.
- Do not promise aid, services or benefits you cannot guarantee.
- Respect gender norms: where appropriate, women should interview women.
- Stop if a question causes distress; offer a break or end the interview.

## Special care

- **Children under 18:** interview only if the protocol allows it, with consent from a parent or guardian and assent from the child.
- **Sensitive topics** such as violence or health: follow the project's specific protocol and referral list.
- **People with disabilities:** adapt communication and allow extra time; never assume someone cannot consent.

! **Safeguarding concerns**
If a respondent tells you about abuse, exploitation or a risk to their safety, do not investigate. Listen calmly, share the referral information if they want it and report to your team leader or safeguarding focal point the same day, following the project's procedure.

PROTECTION

# 03 Data confidentiality and security

**BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO**

- Keep personal information private
- Secure devices, paper forms and recordings
- Share data only through approved channels

Respondents trust you with their information. A leaked list of names, phone numbers or answers can put people at serious risk. Treat all data as confidential.

DEVICES

### Lock and protect

Use a PIN or password on every phone and tablet. Do not share passwords or let others use your device. Keep devices with you at all times.

PAPER

### Keep forms out of sight

Store sample lists, consent forms and notes in a closed folder. Never leave them in a vehicle, office or shared room.

SHARING

### Approved channels only

Send data only through the project's approved system, such as KoboCollect or a secure upload link. Do not send personal data through personal messaging apps or email unless your project explicitly allows it.

TALKING

### Do not discuss answers

Do not discuss what respondents said with anyone outside the project team, including family, friends, officials or program staff.

## Personal identifying information

Names, phone numbers, exact addresses, ID numbers, photos of faces and GPS points can identify a person. Collect them only when the tool requires them, keep them separate from answers where possible, and never include them in notes that will be shared.

✓ **Photos**
Take photos only when the protocol requires them and with permission. Avoid faces, especially of children, unless consent has been given for that specific purpose.

! **After submission**
Once your team leader confirms the data is received and backed up, delete it from personal devices and hand over or securely destroy paper copies, as your project instructs.

BEFORE YOU GO

# 04 Field preparation

**BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO**

- Prepare yourself, your tools and your schedule
- Use the sample list correctly
- Coordinate with respondents before you travel

## The day before

- [ ] Practice the questionnaire or interview guide until you can ask every question smoothly in the local language.
- [ ] Download the latest form version and complete one test entry.
- [ ] Charge your phone or tablet overnight and carry a power bank.
- [ ] Print your sample list, consent forms, interview guide and any observation checklist.
- [ ] Pack your ID card, authorization letter, notebook, pens and recorder if needed.
- [ ] Call respondents or local focal points to confirm appointments for KIIs and FGDs.
- [ ] Agree your route, transport, check-in times and an emergency contact with your team leader.

## Using the sample list

The sample list tells you exactly whom to interview. Interviewing the wrong person is one of the most common and costly errors.

1. Carry the printed list and check each respondent's details before you start.
2. Interview only the person on the list, or the person the selection rule tells you to choose, such as the household head.
3. If the person is absent, revisit at the agreed number of times before replacing them.
4. Use a replacement only from the reserve list and only in the order given. Record the reason for every replacement.
5. Never pick an easier respondent because they are nearby or available.

**Keep a low profile**
Travel and dress simply, avoid displaying expensive equipment and do not attract crowds. A low profile keeps you and respondents safe.

QUANTITATIVE

# 05 Conducting surveys

## BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Run a standard survey interview from start to finish
- Ask questions exactly as written
- Record answers accurately, including GPS

| Locate | Consent | Interview | Check | Finalize |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Right respondent | Read aloud | As written | Before you leave | Send same day |

1. Confirm you have the right respondent from the sample list.
2. Read the consent statement and record consent. If there is no consent, do not continue.
3. Record the GPS location at the start of the interview, and again at the end if the form asks for it.
4. Sit or stand facing the respondent at a comfortable distance.
5. Read each question exactly as written, in order. Do not change the wording, suggest answers or skip questions.
6. Read the answer options only when the form tells you to. Otherwise let the respondent answer freely and select the matching option.
7. If an answer is unclear, repeat the question. Use neutral probes such as "Can you tell me a bit more?"
8. Before you leave, review the form for missing or unusual answers, thank the respondent and finalize the form.

**Do**
Stay neutral, keep a steady pace, record "Don't know" when that is the real answer, and note anything unusual in the comments field.

**Do not**
Add your own extra questions, argue with answers, guess an answer, or let others answer for the respondent.

**Probing extreme answers**
If an answer seems very positive or very negative, or does not match earlier answers, politely confirm it: "Just to make sure I record this correctly, you said...". Record the confirmed answer, not your opinion.

QUALITATIVE

# 06 Key informant interviews

**BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO**

- Prepare and run an in-depth interview
- Use probing questions to reach the why and the how
- Take complete, useful notes

Key informant interviews (KIIs) and in-depth interviews (IDIs) are guided conversations with people who know the topic well, such as officials, program staff, community leaders or service providers.

## Before and during the interview

1. Book an appointment and confirm it the day before. Arrive on time.
2. Work in pairs where possible: one interviewer asks questions and one note taker records answers.
3. Read the consent statement. Ask separately for permission to audio record; record only if they agree.
4. Follow the interview guide in order, but let the conversation flow naturally.
5. Use open questions that start with how, why, what or tell me about. Avoid questions that can be answered with yes or no.
6. Make sure the person understands each question before they answer. Rephrase if needed.
7. Check with your note taker that the answer is fully captured before moving on.
8. At the end, ask if there is anything else they would like to add, and thank them.

PROBING

### Get to the why and the how

When a serious issue comes up, explore it fully: What happened? How did it start? Why did it happen? Who was involved? What was done about it, and by whom? What happened next?

NEUTRALITY

### Manage your reactions

Do not argue, even if the person is upset or critical. Avoid loud reactions such as "oh no" or "really?", which can influence or upset the speaker. Stay calm and keep listening.

**Write notes the same day**

Expand your notes into a full write-up the same evening while you still remember the details. Organize answers under each question and mark direct quotes clearly.

QUALITATIVE

# 07 Focus group discussions

**BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO**

- Set up a focus group correctly
- Moderate so that everyone can speak
- Record the discussion clearly

## Participants

- 6 to 9 people per group, similar in key ways such as sex, age group or role.
- Do not invite the same people to more than one group.
- Give each participant a number (1, 2, 3...) for the notes. Use respectful titles rather than names during the discussion.

## Setting

- A quiet, private place where outsiders cannot listen.
- Seat everyone in a circle so all can see each other.
- Use a printed discussion guide rather than reading from a phone.

## Roles

| Role | Responsibilities |
|---|---|
| Moderator | Introduces the session, reads consent, asks questions in order, encourages quiet participants, keeps dominant voices in check and manages time. |
| Assistant moderator / note taker | Takes notes throughout, operates the recorder, takes permitted photos, notes participant numbers next to comments and records follow-up questions. |

## Moderating well

- Start with simple, warm-up questions before sensitive ones.
- Invite quieter people by name or number: "Participant 4, what is your view?"
- Look for agreement and disagreement: "Does anyone see it differently?"
- Do not share your own opinions or judge answers.
- Close by summarizing the main points and asking if anything was missed.

**Clear notes**
Use the question numbers or codes from the guide as headings, note which participant said what, mark points of agreement and disagreement, and add the follow-up questions you asked.

# 08 QUALITATIVE
# Direct observation

### BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- Use an observation checklist objectively
- Record evidence, not opinions
- Take and label photos correctly

Observation is used to verify what is happening on the ground: whether a facility is functioning, a distribution is organized, a classroom is in session or a structure is built to standard.

1. Get permission from the person in charge of the site before you start.
2. Use the project's observation checklist and complete every item.
3. Observe first, then record. Write what you see and hear, not what you think it means.
4. Where something cannot be observed, mark it as not observed instead of guessing.
5. Take photos only where allowed, avoiding faces, and label each photo with the site code, date and checklist item.
6. Record the GPS location, arrival and departure time.
7. Write short comments to explain any item marked as a problem.

| Instead of this | Write this |
|---|---|
| "The clinic is badly run." | "No staff present at 10:15. Waiting room had 14 patients. Medicine cabinet empty." |
| "Good quality latrine." | "Latrine door locks, floor intact, handwashing station has water and soap." |
| "Teacher seemed lazy." | "Teacher arrived 25 minutes after the scheduled start. 32 of 40 enrolled students present." |

**Be objective**
Your presence can change behavior. Note if staff appeared to prepare for your visit, and visit at the times set in the protocol, including unannounced visits where required.

QUALITY

# 09 Data quality in the field

**BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO**

- Recognize the most common field errors
- Check your own work before submission
- Support team leaders' quality checks

| Principle | What it means in practice |
|---|---|
| Right respondent | Interview only the selected person; check details against the sample list. |
| Complete | Ask every required question. Do not leave blanks unless the form allows them. |
| Accurate | Record exactly what is said. Never change, round or improve answers. |
| Consistent | Check that answers fit together. If someone praises a service but later says they are unhappy with it, politely clarify and note the explanation. |
| In depth | Probe unclear, very positive or very negative answers to understand the reason. |
| Timely | Finalize and submit data the same day so problems can be fixed while you are still in the area. |
| Secure | Protect data from unauthorized access at every stage. |

## Team leader quality checks

- [ ] Accompany each field researcher for at least one interview early in fieldwork.
- [ ] Review submissions daily for missing answers, outliers, very short interviews and GPS points far from the site.
- [ ] Back-check a sample of respondents by phone or revisit to confirm the interview took place.
- [ ] Give feedback the same day and log every correction.

! **Fabrication is detected**
Duplicate patterns, impossible timings, wrong GPS locations and failed back-checks reveal invented data. Fabrication damages the whole project and your professional reputation.

AFTER THE INTERVIEW

# 10 Data handling and submission

**BY THE END OF THIS SECTION YOU WILL BE ABLE TO**

- Submit each type of data correctly and on time
- Prepare interview notes that analysts can use
- Hand over and delete data safely

| What | How | When |
|---|---|---|
| Survey forms | Finalize in KoboCollect (or the project's tool) and send to the server. | Same day, as soon as you have a connection |
| Interview and FGD notes | Typed or entered through the project tool, in the agreed language, with full answers under each question. | Within 24 to 48 hours of the interview |
| Audio recordings | Uploaded through the approved secure channel and named with the site code and date. | As the project instructs, at least at mid and end of fieldwork |
| Consent forms | Handed to the team leader in a sealed folder. | Mid and end of fieldwork |
| Photos | Labeled with site code, date and item; shared only through the approved channel. | End of each day |

## Good interview notes

- Follow the order of the interview guide and put answers under each question.
- Capture the reasons and examples, not only short answers.
- Mark direct quotes in quotation marks.
- Use participant numbers, never names.
- Add the date, location code, interview type and interviewer code at the top.

! **Never keep or share copies**
Do not keep personal copies of data or share it with anyone for safekeeping. After your team leader confirms receipt, delete data from your device and return paper materials.

REFERENCE

# 11 Quick reference

**EVERY MORNING**

- [ ] Device charged, form updated, power bank packed
- [ ] Sample list, consent forms and guides printed
- [ ] ID and authorization letter with you
- [ ] Route and check-in times agreed
- [ ] Appointments confirmed

**EVERY EVENING**

- [ ] All forms finalized and sent
- [ ] Notes written up and submitted
- [ ] Photos and recordings labeled
- [ ] Problems reported to team leader
- [ ] Paper forms stored securely

**Always**

Get consent first · Interview the right person · Ask questions as written · Probe for the why · Stay neutral · Protect privacy · Submit the same day · Report problems early

**Never**

Invent or change answers · Accept gifts · Promise benefits · Argue with respondents · Share data outside the team · Use unapproved apps for personal data · Keep copies after submission

## Key terms

**Informed consent**
A person's voluntary agreement to take part after understanding the purpose, risks and their rights.

**KII**
Key informant interview: an in-depth interview with someone who knows the topic well.

**FGD**
Focus group discussion: a guided discussion with 6 to 9 similar participants.

**Probing**
Neutral follow-up questions that help a respondent explain more.

**Back-check**
Re-contacting a sample of respondents to confirm interviews took place correctly.

**Personal identifying information**
Any detail that can identify a person, such as a name, phone number or exact location.